journey, giving him all the advice he could. He also gave him the signal honour of being allowed a crimson tent, a prerogative of the Padshah, and then returned to Agra.

Raja Man Singh, now Subedar of Bengal, arrived at court bringing extravagant presents including fifty large diamonds. It was Man Singh who would finally be able to integrate Bengal into the Mughal Empire within a few years. In 1602, he established Dhaka as his military headquarters and soon ‘rice was being exported throughout the Indian Ocean to points as far west as Goa and as far east as the Moluccas in Southeast Asia’. Fine muslin cloth from Bengal came to be called Daka in the export markets of Asia and Bengal became ‘a major producer for the imperial court’s voracious appetite for luxury goods’ such as raw silk and cotton cloths.

Hearing of the favour being shown to Daniyal, Salim hurried to court and wanted to present himself to his father but Akbar refused to receive him because Salim, ‘from drunkenness and bad companionship did not distinguish between his own good and evil’. It finally took the efforts of Hamida Banu to soothe the annoyance of the Padshah before Salim was allowed to pay obeisance at court. If Akbar was angry at the prince for not having obeyed instructions to march to the Deccan, then Salim would have been humiliated and shaken to hear of Daniyal having been granted the royal crimson tents. The symbols of imperial authority were sacrosanct and untouchable. Objects like the Padshah’s throne, his umbrella, fan, flags, and standards were exclusively his to use and were an explicit visual reminder of his blessed presence. The fluttering crimson tents, immediately recognizable to all from a distance, would have been powerfully symbolic and Salim would have clearly understood the significance of this immense honour. Akbar directed Salim to proceed to Ajmer to tend to the situation with Mewar* along with Raja Man Singh which Salim did but the prince, now bristly with frustration, began brooding over a final confrontation with his father.

Since Daniyal was not proceeding towards the Deccan with the alacrity and dedication expected of him, Akbar decided to go to Malwa, where Daniyal was camped, to organize a hunt and thereby bolster the prince’s faltering resolve. Akbar’s foray into the Deccan would be the last significant military expedition of his reign. With his western and north-western frontier settled and Bengal temporarily quiet, the next logical direction for the Mughal Padshah was south. Indeed, it was not only